# Agnes of God
## by John Pielmeier

**AGNES:** *(singing off stage)* ***Gratias agimum tibi propter magnam gloriam tuam.**
*Domine Deus. Rex coelestis. Deus pater omnipotens. Domini Fili unigenite. Jesu Christe*

**DOCTOR:** **(Pg 3-4)** *(Speaking over Agnes)* The baby was discovered in a wastepaper basket with the umbilical cord knotted around its neck. The mother was found unconscious by the door to her room, suffering from excessive loss of blood. She was indicted for manslaughter and brought to trial. Her case was assigned to me, Doctor Martha Livingstone, as court psychiatrist, to determine whether she was legally sane. I wanted to help this young woman, believe me . . .

## INTRODUCTION

*Agnes of God by John Pielmeier*

**DOCTOR:** **(Pg 17)** Hello. I'm Doctor Livingstone. I've been asked to talk to you. May I?

**AGNES:** **(Pg 20-22)** You want to talk about the baby, don't you?

**DOCTOR:** Would you like to talk about it?

**AGNES:** I never saw any baby . . . I think they made it up.

**DOCTOR:** Do you remember the night they said it came? Did it hurt?

**AGNES:** Yes.

**DOCTOR:** Where did the baby come from?

**AGNES:** They say it came from the wastepaper basket.

**DOCTOR:** But where did it come from before that?

**AGNES:** From God.

**DOCTOR:** ***After*** God, ***before*** the wastepaper basket.

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**AGNES:** I don't know what you're talking about! Everybody wants to talk about the baby, but I never saw the baby, so I can't talk about the baby, because I don't believe in the baby! Nobody listens to me! *(Silence)* **(Pg 24)** Where do **you** think babies come from?

**DOCTOR:** From their mothers and fathers, of course. Before that, I don't know.

**AGNES:** Well, I think they come from when an angel lights on their mother's chest and whispers into her ear. That makes good babies start to grow. Bad babies come from a fallen angel. *(Silence)* Bad babies cry a lot and make their fathers go away and their mothers get very ill and die sometimes. Mummy wasn't very happy when ***she*** died and I think she went to hell. *(Silence)* **(Pg 33)** But she watches. She listens.

**DOCTOR:** **(Pg 42-46)** Agnes, have you ever thought of leaving the convent? For something else?

**AGNES:** Oh no. There's nothing else. It makes me happy. Just being here helps me sleep at night.

**DOCTOR:** You have trouble sleeping?

**AGNES:** I get headaches. Mummy did too. She'd lie in the dark with a wet cloth over her face and tell me to go away. Oh, but she wasn't stupid. Oh no, she was very smart. She knew everything. Things nobody else knew. She told me I would enter the convent, and I did. She even knew about this.

**DOCTOR:** How did she know . . . about this?

**AGNES:** Somebody told her.

**DOCTOR:** Who?

**AGNES:** You'll laugh.

**DOCTOR:** I promise I won't laugh. Who told her?

**AGNES:** An angel. When she was having one of her headaches.

**DOCTOR:** Do you believe that your mother really saw them?

**AGNES:** No. But I could never tell her that. She'd get angry. She'd punish me.

**DOCTOR:** How would she punish you?

**AGNES:** She'd . . . punish me.

**DOCTOR:** Did you love your mother?

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**AGNES:** Oh, yes. Yes.

**DOCTOR:** Did you ever want to become a mother yourself?

**AGNES:** I could never be a mother. I don't think I'm old enough. Besides, I don't want a baby.

**DOCTOR:** But if you did want one, how would you go about getting one?

**AGNES:** From someone who didn't want a baby.

**DOCTOR:** Like you?

**AGNES:** No! Not like me. A mistake.

**DOCTOR:** How did your mother get you?

**AGNES:** A mistake! It was a mistake!

**DOCTOR:** Is that what she said?

**AGNES:** You're trying to get me to say that she was a bad woman, and that she hated me, and she didn't want me, but that is not true, she was a good woman, a saint, and she ***did*** want me. You don't want to hear the nice parts about her—all you're interested in is sickness!

**DOCTOR:** Agnes, I cannot imagine that you know nothing about sex. . .

**AGNES:** I can't help it if I'm stupid.

**DOCTOR:** . . . that you have no idea who the father of your child was . . .

**AGNES:** They made it up! It's not my fault!

**DOCTOR:** . . . and that you don't believe that you carried a child!

**AGNES:** It was a mistake!

**DOCTOR:** What, the child?

**AGNES:** Everything! Nuns don't have children!

**DOCTOR:** Agnes. . .

**AGNES:** Don't touch me like that! Don't touch me like that! *(Agnes lashes out at the doctor, who moves away)* I know what you want from me! You want to take God away. You should be ashamed! They should lock ***you*** up. People like you! *(Long beat)*

**DOCTOR:** **(Pg 55)** *(to audience)* I wanted to free Agnes – I wanted to make her well.

**AGNES:** I'm not sick!

**DOCTOR:** **(Pg 57-62)** But you're troubled, aren't you?

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**AGNES:** That's because you keep reminding me. If you go away, then I'll forget.

**DOCTOR:** And you're unhappy.

**AGNES:** Everyone's unhappy! You're unhappy, aren't you?

**DOCTOR:** Sometimes, yes.

**AGNES:** Only you think you're lucky because you didn't have a mother who said things to you and did things that maybe weren't always nice, but that's what you think, because you don't know that my mother was a wonderful person, and even if you did know that you wouldn't believe it because you think she was bad, don't you?

**DOCTOR:** Agnes.

**AGNES:** Answer me! You never answer me!

**DOCTOR:** Yes, I do think your mother was wrong, sometimes.

**AGNES:** But that was because of me! Because ***I*** was bad, not her!

**DOCTOR:** What did you do?

**AGNES:** I'm always bad.

**DOCTOR:** What do you do?

**AGNES:** *(in tears)* I breathe!

**DOCTOR:** What did your mother do to you? *(No answer)* If you can't tell me, shake your head, yes or no. Did she hit you? *(Agnes shakes her head "No")* Did she make you do something you didn't want to do? *(Agnes nods "Yes")* Did it make you uncomfortable to do this? *(Agnes nods "Yes")* Did it embarrass you? *(Agnes nods "Yes")* Did it hurt you? *(Agnes nods "Yes")* What did she make you do?

**AGNES:** No.

**DOCTOR:** You can tell me. She's dead. She can't hurt you anymore.

**AGNES:** She can. She watches, she listens.

**DOCTOR:** Agnes, I don't believe that. Tell me. I'll protect you from her.

**AGNES:** She. . . makes me. . . take off my clothes and then. . . she makes . . . fun of me.

**DOCTOR:** She tells you you're ugly? *(Agnes nods "Yes")* And that you're stupid.

**AGNES:** Yes.

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**DOCTOR:** And you're a mistake.

**AGNES:** She says. . . my whole body. . . is a mistake. She says. . . if I don't watch out. . . I'll have a baby. And then. . . she touches me down there with her cigarette. *(Silence)* Please, Mummy. Don't. I'll be good, I won't be your bad baby anymore. *(Silence)*

**DOCTOR:** Agnes, dear, I want you to do something. I want you to pretend that I'm your mother. Only this time, I want you to tell me what you're feeling. All right?

**AGNES:** I'm afraid.

**DOCTOR:** *(She takes Agnes' face in her hands)* Please. I want to help you. Let me help you. *(Silence)* Agnes, you're ugly. What do you say to that?

**AGNES:** I don't know.

**DOCTOR:** Of course you do. Agnes, you're ugly. What do you say?

**AGNES:** No, I'm not.

**DOCTOR:** Are you pretty?

**AGNES:** Yes.

**DOCTOR:** Agnes, you're stupid.

**AGNES:** No, I'm not.

**DOCTOR:** Agnes, you're a mistake.

**AGNES:** I'm not a mistake! I'm here, aren't I? How can I be a mistake if I'm really here? God doesn't make mistakes. ***You're*** a mistake! I wish you were dead! *(shocked silence, then Agnes begins to cry. The doctor takes her in her arms)*

**DOCTOR:** Agnes, I'd like to ask a favor of you. You can say no, if you don't like what I'm asking. I'd like permission to hypnotize you. There are some things that you might be able to tell me under hypnosis that you aren't able to tell me now. *(to audience)* The hypnosis took weeks to achieve, not minutes. An hour a day . . .

**AGNES:** **(Pg 77-79)** I'm frightened!

**DOCTOR:** Don't be. I cannot make you say or do anything you do not wish to say or do. Sit back and relax. Imagine that you are listening to a chorus of angels. Breathe freely and deeply. Close your eyes, Agnes. When I count to three, you will wake up. Can you hear me?

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**AGNES:** Yes.

**DOCTOR:** Good. Would you like to tell me why you're here?

**AGNES:** Because I'm in trouble.

**DOCTOR:** What kind of trouble?

**AGNES:** *(Agnes struggles, then says)* I had a baby. I was afraid.

**DOCTOR:** Why were you afraid?

**AGNES:** Because I wasn't worthy.

**DOCTOR:** To be a mother?

**AGNES:** Yes. *(she begins to cry softly)*

**DOCTOR:** **(Pg 81-83)** All right, Agnes, I'm going to ask you to open your eyes. When you do, you will see your room at the convent. It is the night about four months ago when you were very sick. All right, Agnes, let's go to your room. Ready? What do you see?

**AGNES:** My bed. A crucifix.

**DOCTOR:** Anything else? *(Silence)* Agnes? What do you see? Something different? Something that's not normally in the room?

**AGNES:** A wastepaper basket. *(Silence)*

**DOCTOR:** Do you know who put it there?

**AGNES:** No.

**DOCTOR:** Why do you think it's there?

**AGNES:** For me to get sick in.

**DOCTOR:** Are you ill?

**AGNES:** Yes. **(Pg 84-85)** Oh God! *(she holds her stomach in a contraction)* Oh my God. Water. . . it's all water!

**DOCTOR:** Why doesn't anyone come?

**AGNES:** They can't hear me. Get away from me. Go away! I don't want you here!

**DOCTOR:** Is someone in the room with you? Agnes?

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**AGNES:** Don't touch me! Don't touch me! Please! Please don't touch me! *(Contraction)* You want to hurt my baby! You want to take my baby! *(Screams and contraction)* It's not my fault, Mummy. It's a mistake, Mummy. **(Pg 105)** Your fault! It's all your fault!

**DOCTOR:** **(Pg 85)** Agnes, it's all right. It's all right. It's me. Doctor Livingstone. It's all right. *(Agnes relaxes)*

**AGNES:** **(Pg 105-108)** *(softly)* I hate him. I hate him for what he did to me.

**DOCTOR:** Tell us who he is so we can find him and stop him from doing this to other women. Who did this to you?

**AGNES:** God! God did it to me! It was God! And now I'll burn in hell because I hate Him!

**DOCTOR:** Agnes, you won't burn in hell. It's all right to hate him. *(beat)* Agnes, what happened to the baby? It was alive, wasn't it? ***Wasn't it?***

**AGNES:** YES!!! *(Silence)* I don't want to remember.

**DOCTOR:** Mother Miriam was with you, wasn't she? You saw it all, didn't you? *(no response)* What did she do? *(Silence)* Agnes, what did she do?

**AGNES:** *(Simply and quietly)* She left me alone with that little. . . thing. I looked at it and thought, this is a mistake. But it's my mistake, not Mummy's. God's mistake. I thought, I can save her. I can give her back to God. *(Silence)*

**DOCTOR:** What did you do?

**AGNES:** I put her to sleep. I tied the cord around her neck, wrapped her in the bloody sheets, and stuffed her in the trash can.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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## AWARDS

*2020 National Qualifier*
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**** Glory to God (Gloria) is a well-known religious hymn – Agnes would have sung in the original Latin.***

***The song has been adapted by churches over time and a modern English version (Music and Lyrics) can be found here which may be utilized for this selection https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8AK9zPuyQ2o***

***Translation from Latin***

***Thanks we give to thee because of great glory thy***
***Lord God.***
***King of heaven.***
***God father almighty.***
***Lord Son only begotten,***
***Jesus Christ.***

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